



United States
Attorney's Office
Western District of Washington



Two brothers from India arraigned on indictment for selling counterfeit cancer drugs and adulterated medications

Friday, February 28, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Western District of Washington

Men are extradited from Singapore following their 2023 arrest after FDA and ICE undercover probe

Seattle – Two brothers from India appeared in court today on a 2022 indictment for multiple counts related to their scheme to sell counterfeit and adulterated drugs in the United States, announced Acting U.S. Attorney Teal Luthy Miller. Avanish Kumar Jha, 38, and Rajnish Kumar Jha, 35, were arrested in Singapore on April 20, 2023, based on a request from the United States. In January 2025, a judge in Singapore ruled the men could be extradited to the U.S. to face 28 felony charges and the Minister for Law ordered their surrender on February 24, 2025. Both defendants entered pleas of not guilty and trial was scheduled for May 5, 2025, in front of U.S. District Judge Ricardo S. Martinez.

“The defendants in this case allegedly made hundreds of thousands of dollars while defrauding people who were clinging to hope that a late-stage cancer medication could save their life. Because of this fraud, victims received counterfeit medication that contained none of the cancer-fighting substance they thought they were ordering,” said Acting U.S. Attorney Miller. “This fraud scheme didn’t just steal money; it stole the prospect of more time with loved ones for those battling cancer.”

The investigation of the Jha brothers began in 2019, when investigators reviewed internet postings and other evidence indicating that the Jha brothers and their company, Dhrishti Pharma International, were offering to sell prescription drugs to buyers in the United States and elsewhere. Undercover agents with the Office of Criminal Investigations (OCI) of the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) and U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) Homeland Security Investigations (HSI) began communicating with the Jha brothers and ordered some of their products. Of particular concern was a “medication” labeled as “Keytruda,” a Merck drug for late-stage cancer. An analysis revealed that the

Jha brothers were selling counterfeit Keytruda that contained none of active ingredient that made the authentic product effective. Other products contained contaminants.

The brothers allegedly shipped the counterfeit and adulterated drugs from India. They accepted various means of payment including wire transfers and direct money exchanges. In some cases, they used intermediaries in the United States to pick up cash payments. The drugs were packaged in such a way to avoid detection by international customs or other regulators.

Both men had been detained in Singapore since their arrest in April 2023 based on a provisional arrest request from the United States. The United States submitted a formal extradition request to Singapore in June 2023.

"This case highlights ICE HSI's commitment to protecting the public from dangerous and fraudulent practices that put vulnerable individuals at risk," said acting Special Agent in Charge of ICE HSI Seattle Matthew Murphy. "The company in question preyed on those in desperate need of lifesaving treatments by offering counterfeit medications that provided nothing but false hope. Thanks to the diligent work of our special agents and our law enforcement partners, we are taking swift action to ensure those responsible are held accountable."

The case was investigated by the Food and Drug Administration's Office of Criminal Investigations and ICE HSI.

The case is being prosecuted by Assistant United States Attorney Philip Kopczynski. The U.S. Department of Justice's Office of International Affairs provided valuable assistance with securing the extradition. Significant assistance was provided by law enforcement partners at the U.S. Embassy in Singapore, including the ICE HSI Attaché and the U.S. Department of State's Diplomatic Security Service Office of Overseas Criminal Investigations, and Singaporean authorities, particularly the Singapore Police Force and Attorney-General's Chambers.

Contact

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